

Tai Chi for Arthritis: Why the Recommends It

This ancient Chinese practice is now one of the most evidence-backed exercises for arthritis. Discover how to get started in the UK.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Tai Chi for Arthritis



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Tai chi — an ancient Chinese practice combining slow, flowing movements with deep breathing and meditation — has become one of the most recommended exercises for arthritis worldwide. The evidence is so strong that ****NICE, the NHS, and Arthritis Research UK**** all endorse it.

The Evidence

A landmark 2016 study in the **Annals of Internal Medicine** found that tai chi was ****as effective as standard physiotherapy**** for knee osteoarthritis, with benefits lasting 12 months. Participants reported significant improvements in: - Pain reduction (52% improvement) - Physical function - Depression and anxiety symptoms - Self-efficacy (confidence in managing their condition)

A Cochrane review covering 7 trials and 345 participants confirmed moderate evidence for reduced pain and improved function in knee and hip OA.



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How Tai Chi Helps Arthritis

****Muscle strengthening without impact:**** The slow, controlled movements build strength in the legs, core, and upper body without the joint stress of traditional resistance training.

****Balance improvement:**** Falls are a major risk for people with arthritis. Tai chi reduces fall risk by up to 50% in older adults (BMJ, 2017) by improving proprioception and ankle stability.

****Pain gate theory:**** Focused, meditative movement can "close the gate" on pain signals in the spinal cord, reducing the brain's perception of pain.



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****Stress reduction:**** The breathing and mindfulness components lower cortisol levels, which reduces systemic inflammation.

Getting Started in the UK

****Tai Chi for Arthritis programme**** Developed by Dr Paul Lam (an arthritis sufferer himself), this programme is specifically designed for people with joint conditions. It's endorsed by Arthritis Research UK and taught by certified instructors across the UK.

****Finding a class:**** - Search the Tai Chi Union for Great Britain (TCUGB) instructor directory - Ask your local leisure centre — many now offer tai chi alongside yoga and Pilates - Arthritis UK lists arthritis-friendly exercise classes by postcode - Many community centres and village halls host weekly sessions (typically £5–8)

****Online options:**** - Dr Paul Lam's official DVD and streaming service - YouTube: Search "Tai Chi for Arthritis beginners" - NHS Fitness Studio offers free tai chi videos

What to Expect in Your First Class

- Sessions typically last 45–60 minutes
- No special equipment needed — just comfortable clothing and flat shoes
- Most movements can be performed seated if needed
- You'll learn 6–12 basic forms (movements) initially
- The pace is gentle — tai chi is not competitive

Tips for Arthritis Patients

- ****Start with seated tai chi**** if balance is a concern
- ****Avoid deep knee bends**** — modify stances to stay comfortable
- ****Practice daily at home**** — even 10 minutes reinforces what you learn in class
- ****Don't expect instant results**** — benefits typically emerge after 6–8 weeks of regular practice
- ****Tell your instructor**** about your arthritis so they can suggest modifications

Key Takeaway

Tai chi is a gentle yet powerful tool for managing arthritis. It strengthens your body, calms your mind, and reduces your pain — all at your own pace.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about tai chi for arthritis: why the recommends it?

Short answer: Tai chi, an ancient Chinese exercise, combines slow movements with deep breathing to help manage arthritis. It strengthens muscles without joint impact, improves balance, and reduces pain and stress. Benefits typically emerge after 6–8 weeks of regular practice, with sessions often lasting 45–60 minutes. Many classes teach the Tai Chi for Arthritis programme, specifically designed for people with joint conditions.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk